

FAR-SIDS Systematic Review Protocol

Foreign aid, remittances, and wellbeing in Small Island Developing States: a systematic review of methods, variables, and evidence.

Version 1.7, 14 September 2026. Prepared by Roxane de Waegh (MSCA Fellow, Islands and Small States Institute, University of Malta), with Professor Stefano Moncada (supervisor). Intended for registration on OSF Registries. Follows the PRISMA 2020 reporting guideline and the PRISMA-P protocol structure.

The criteria in section 3 were fixed before screening began and amended three times as screening proceeded: the wellbeing or livelihood outcome criterion was clarified to apply broadly, the setting criterion was reworded so that a study qualifies on what its design teaches as well as on where it is set, and the exclusion reasons gained two categories that the full text stage made necessary. Every amendment is dated in the review's search record, which also holds the exact search strings, the date each search was run, and the count at every stage.

1. Background and rationale

Small Island Developing States receive some of the world's largest flows of foreign aid and remittances relative to the size of their economies, yet the evidence on how those flows translate into wellbeing and livelihoods on the ground is scattered across disciplines and methods. This review maps that evidence systematically: what has been studied, with which methods and models, drawing on which variables, and whether any prior work has combined ethnography, household surveys, and time series econometrics in a single design. The conceptual frame is the Sustainable Livelihoods Framework read through the aid and remittance nexus, against the three FAR-SIDS case countries, Jamaica, Tonga, and Comoros. The review is framed against the State of SIDS Report 2026 from ODI Global.

2. Objectives and review questions

The review answers four questions:

1. What has already been studied on foreign aid and remittances in relation to wellbeing and livelihoods in SIDS, and where are the gaps?
2. Which methods and models were used, with particular attention to time series econometrics (ARDL), ethnography, and household surveys?
3. Has any prior work combined ethnography, household surveys, and ARDL econometrics in one design? This is the methodological claim to novelty, so it needs an evidence based answer.
4. Which dependent and independent variables did those studies use?

Framed as a single question: among studies of SIDS and comparable small economies, how do foreign aid and remittances relate to wellbeing and livelihood outcomes, what methods and variables have been used to measure that relationship, and has any study integrated ethnography, household surveys, and ARDL econometrics?

3. Eligibility criteria

Include a study if it meets all of the following:

- Empirical (data collected and analysed, through econometrics, household surveys, ethnography, or mixed methods), or a strong conceptual contribution (a structured framework, theory, or evidence grounded argument), on foreign aid or remittances, or both.
- Reports a wellbeing or livelihood outcome (for example welfare, poverty, food security, human development, resilience, standard of living, or a livelihoods dimension). This criterion is applied broadly: resilience includes community, societal, and regional resilience, not only the household level, and the wellbeing pathway may be indirect. A study of aid or remittance policy qualifies where the policy plausibly bears on the wellbeing or livelihoods of people in the affected states, for example a study of aid as a geopolitical or security instrument whose programmes build resilience in, and affect the populations of, recipient states. A study whose outcomes are only macroeconomic (for example growth, exchange rates, or financial development) qualifies where foreign aid or remittances is the object of study and the setting criterion below is met; such studies form a distinct macro stratum, extracted for their variables, data sources, and methods to inform the review's econometric strand, and reported as context in the synthesis rather than as wellbeing evidence. A study where aid or remittances appears only as a control variable or as background context does not qualify.
- Set in a Small Island Developing State, or a study whose findings or design transfer to the SIDS context. The test is not whether SIDS sit inside the sample. A study qualifies in either of two ways: by telling us something about aid or remittances and wellbeing that reaches SIDS, directly or by transfer; or by teaching us how to do the work, meaning a method, a measure, an identification strategy, a variable set, or a way of handling thin data or remote fieldwork. A study fails this criterion only where all three of the following hold together: the SIDS presence is barely there, the outcomes are purely macroeconomic, and there is nothing in the design that could be carried into the present study. A stated method label is not on its own a reason to include, and a study that pools SIDS with other economies is judged on what its approach, variables or wellbeing indicators would change in the design of this review.
- Peer reviewed literature, or substantial grey literature (an institutional report with a clear method or data, for example from the World Bank, IMF, ODI, UNCTAD, or regional development banks; not a blog, press release, or think piece).
- Written in English, French, or Spanish (French for the Comoros literature; Spanish for the wider Caribbean and Latin American literature).
- Published within the last 20 years, 2006 to present. The window is judged on the publication date, so a study published within the window whose data predate it is eligible, and the data vintage is carried into the synthesis as a caveat. A study published before 2006 is admitted only where the reviewer records what that study supplies and no study inside the window does; two studies are admitted on that basis and both carry their publication dates into the synthesis.

Exclude a study if it is:

- A macroeconomic study in which foreign aid or remittances is not the object of study but appears only as a control variable or background context. These are logged with the reason "not about aid or remittances". The size of the macro literature relative to the wellbeing literature remains a reported finding, captured through the macro stratum of included studies.
- An opinion piece, editorial, commentary, op-ed, or news item that only asserts a view, with no empirical or strong conceptual contribution.
- An existing systematic or literature review on this topic. These are not included as studies; their reference lists are instead mined through citation searching, to avoid double counting.

- A study with critical methodological flaws, meaning a study that is on topic and within scope but whose method cannot yield a finding the review could use: an untested causal channel presented as a finding, headline results resting on bivariate correlations that plainly reflect confounding, a sample or period the paper states inconsistently and never resolves, or comparable defects. This is a judgement about quality rather than scope; it is recorded with the specific defect named, and it is used sparingly.
- A container record, meaning an edited volume or whole proceedings retrieved as one file while its chapters or papers were screened as separate records. The container is excluded so the same content is not counted twice.
- Not retrievable in full text after reasonable effort. This reason applies at the full text stage only; at title and abstract screening, a record that cannot be judged is retained under the doubt rule rather than excluded. A record whose attached file turns out to be a copy of a different, already screened work is treated as not retrieved, not as a screening decision, until the correct text is obtained.

Duplicate files, meaning the same study retrieved twice, are logged as duplicate records in the flow diagram and not as screening decisions, following PRISMA 2020, which handles duplicates before the eligibility stage. A duplicate claim is checked against the files themselves, by hash or by text, not against filenames.

The criteria were calibrated with the supervisor, who reviewed an early batch of about fifty records and agreed that screening should continue. The outcome criterion was clarified once more during screening, and that clarification is dated in the search record.

4. Information sources

Two arms, both reported in the PRISMA flow diagram.

Arm one, database searches (the reproducible core). Four databases were searched: Scopus, Web of Science, EBSCOhost and EconBiz. EconLit was the planned economics database and it is not held in the University of Malta subscription, so an EBSCOhost search and the free economics database EconBiz, maintained by the ZBW Leibniz Information Centre for Economics, were used in its place. The EBSCOhost search ran across fourteen databases at once rather than against Academic Search Ultimate alone. For each database the exact search string, the date run, and the number of records retrieved are recorded in the search record.

Arm two, other methods. A Google Scholar coverage check, and citation searching both backward, screening the reference lists of key reports and included studies, and forward, the works that cite them. Google Scholar sits in this arm rather than in arm one because its results were screened at title level at source and never exported, so no Google Scholar record passed through de-duplication or title and abstract screening and none is counted in the identification total of arm one. No separate sweep of grey literature repositories was run; institutional reports entered the review through the two routes above. Records found in this arm are logged separately and counted in the other methods column of the flow diagram.

French has been among the eligible languages since the second version of this protocol, so the francophone literature, including the Comoros literature, has been eligible at every stage; the scarcity of Comoros specific studies documented at the close of full text screening is reported as a finding of the review.

5. Search strategy

The core search combines three concept blocks with AND: the flows (foreign aid, official development assistance, ODA, remittances), the outcomes (wellbeing, livelihoods, welfare, poverty, human development, resilience), and the setting (small island developing states, SIDS, small states, island economies, Pacific, Caribbean, Indian Ocean, and the three case countries). A fourth, methods block (ARDL, cointegration, time series, ethnography, household survey, mixed methods) is applied as a refinement to answer the methods and integration questions.

Two searches are run in each database. A broad mapping search captures studies on either flow, aid or remittances, with an outcome in the SIDS setting. A targeted nexus search requires both foreign aid and remittances in the same study, to surface the rare work that examines them together. The contrast between a large mapping set and a very small nexus set is itself evidence of the gap. The nine strings as run, with their dates, are held in the search record.

The search terms were developed with citation mapping tools (Connected Papers, Research Rabbit, Litmaps) and AI semantic tools (Elicit, Consensus), used to learn the field and identify seed papers. That work is not a counted source and no record enters the flow diagram through it, because its results are not fully reproducible. An activity becomes counted screening at the point where it is carried out under the fixed eligibility criteria with its numbers logged.

6. Study records and selection process

Data management. All records are exported to the FAR-SIDS Zotero group library, then combined and de-duplicated in two stages: the TERA Deduplicator (Bond University, tera-tools.com, Focused algorithm), followed by Rayyan's own duplicate detection. TERA was used because Rayyan charges for de-duplication and TERA is free, and because it produces an exportable file of the records it removes, which is retained. Of 1,690 records identified across the four databases, 557 duplicates were removed, 536 in TERA and 21 in Rayyan, leaving 1,133 unique records for screening.

Selection. Identification: all records from both arms exported to Zotero, then de-duplicated. Screening: titles and abstracts in Rayyan against the section 3 criteria, single reviewer, with the supervisor reviewing an early batch. Eligibility: full text review of every record that passes. Included: the final set carried into extraction. The full text stage used AI assistance under a fixed rubric to produce one recommendation per record together with its evidence, and the reviewer read every full text and ruled on every recommendation; every screening decision in the review is the reviewer's. The number entering and leaving at each stage is logged for the PRISMA 2020 flow diagram, with reasons recorded at the full text stage.

7. Data extraction

One row per included study in a structured evidence table, with fixed fields: citation; country or region; aid, remittances, or both; outcome (dependent) variables; independent variables; data source and years; method; whether ethnography, household survey, econometrics, or a combination; key finding; and a note on quality or limitations. Extracted values are checked against the source.

SIDS evidence. A further field registers the basis on which each included study speaks to SIDS. It takes one of five values:

- All SIDS: the whole study is set in SIDS.
- Separate SIDS result: the sample is mixed, but SIDS receive their own estimate.
- SIDS not separated: SIDS are verifiably in the sample, but no SIDS specific result is reported.
- Sample not stated: the study never enumerates its sample, so SIDS membership cannot be checked either way.
- No SIDS, transferable: the sample is stated and contains no SIDS, and the study is kept for what it teaches.

The field keeps evidence about SIDS distinct from evidence that merely contains SIDS, so that the synthesis can report how many studies estimate a SIDS specific effect and how many include SIDS without isolating them, rather than blurring the two. "Sample not stated" is held apart from "No SIDS, transferable" because a study that says nothing about its sample is making a different claim from one that lists a sample without SIDS in it; for eligibility it behaves like "No SIDS", since membership cannot be claimed and the study must qualify on the teaching limb alone, and for synthesis it is reported separately, because how much of this literature does not disclose its own sample is itself a finding.

8. Synthesis

A narrative and tabular synthesis organised around the four review questions. No meta-analysis is planned, because the methods and outcomes are expected to be too heterogeneous to pool. Particular weight falls on two columns: the variables, which become the candidate list for the econometric models, and the integration question, which is where the paper stakes its contribution. The macro stratum of included studies, where aid or remittances is the object of study but the outcomes are macroeconomic only, is characterised descriptively as context, to show how a wellbeing and livelihoods lens differs from the existing macroeconomic work. Study quality and limitations are appraised descriptively and carried into the synthesis rather than through a single formal risk of bias instrument, given the mixed methods nature of the evidence.

9. Limitations of the review process

One reviewer screened every record at both stages, and no second reviewer worked independently on any part of the review, so no agreement statistic exists and the consistency of the screening cannot be measured from the record. At the full text stage the reviewer worked against an AI assisted pass that produced one recommendation per record together with its supporting evidence, and the adjudication of that pass is the only reliability evidence the review holds. It shows the pass to have been wrong often enough that its recommendations could not have stood on their own.

Of the 270 distinct studies assessed at full text, the pass returned a definite recommendation on 212 and referred the remaining 58 as undecidable. The reviewer reversed 35 of the 212, a sixth of the definite recommendations, and settled the 58 referrals at 34 inclusions and 24 exclusions. Had the recommendations stood unadjudicated, the review would have carried 136 studies rather than 187. Sixty of the 187 included studies, just under a third of them, entered the review only because

the reviewer read the full text: 26 that the pass had recommended excluding, and 34 that it could not decide. Nine studies the pass recommended including were excluded once read.

We read these figures as a limitation of the method rather than of the tool. The reversals concentrate in the judgements the criteria leave to the reader, the setting criterion and the boundary of the macro stratum, and those are the judgements a second human reviewer would test. A second reviewer working independently would have produced a measurable agreement statistic for the full text stage, would have forced the 58 referrals to be resolved by discussion against the criteria rather than by one reading of them, and would have given the title and abstract stage a check it never had. That first stage is the weaker of the two, because 851 records were excluded there on a single reading, with no recommendation to disagree with and no itemised reasons carried into the record, so none of it can be reconstructed from what the review reports.

10. Registration, reporting, and roles

The protocol is registered on OSF Registries for transparency, PROSPERO being reserved largely for health reviews. Reporting follows PRISMA 2020, including the flow diagram. Roxane de Waegh leads the review; Professor Stefano Moncada supervises and reviews the early screening batch. FAR-SIDS is a two year Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions postdoctoral fellowship at the Islands and Small States Institute, University of Malta, examining how foreign aid and remittances interact to support livelihoods across Small Island Developing States, with Jamaica, Tonga and the Comoros as case countries.